

Exegesis of Acts 20:7-12

Marcus Larsen

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Professor Karl Kuhn

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⁷ On the first day of the week, when we met to break bread, Paul was holding a discussion with them; since he intended to leave the next day, he continued speaking until midnight. ⁸ There were many lamps in the room upstairs where we were meeting. ⁹ A young man named Eutychus, who was sitting in the window, began to sink off into a deep sleep while Paul talked still longer. Overcome by sleep, he fell to the ground three floors below and was picked up dead. ¹⁰ But Paul went down, and bending over him took him in his arms, and said, "Do not be alarmed, for his life is in him." ¹¹ Then Paul went upstairs, and after he had broken bread and eaten, he continued to converse with them until dawn; then he left. ¹² Meanwhile they had taken the boy away alive and were not a little comforted. (Ac. 20:7-12)

Luke's record of Paul's second visit to the Christian community in Troas presents unique elements of both the historical and theological dimensions of Paul's journey. The narrative offers a remarkably detailed portrayal of Paul's worship practices with the Troasian Christians, which may also reveal the broader worship customs of the early Christian church. As the protagonist of Luke's narrative, Paul demonstrates his valid apostolic authority through the resurrection of the unfortunate Eutychus. This self-contained narrative, seemingly juxtaposed in the middle of Paul's return to Jerusalem, contains a mixture of detail, ambiguity, tragedy, and comfort, leaving the audience members feeling like onlookers of the recent astonishing events.

Paul's return to Jerusalem was marked in relation to his relation to Jewish festivals. His departure from Philippi was noted by Luke as occurring "after the days of Unleavened Bread" (20:6). Additionally, Luke notes Paul's eagerness "to be in Jerusalem, if possible, on the day of Pentecost," (20:16). Consequently, Paul and his company must pass by Ephesus and Asia so that they might reach Jerusalem in time. The demarcation of Paul's journey using references to Semitic festivals demonstrates Paul's continued appeal to the character of Judaism that is seen throughout his Jewish ministry (Johnson 355). Despite his urgency, Paul still devotes a week to spending time with the Christian community in Troas. Paul's first and previous visit with the church in Troas was cut short to only a day due to an unforeseen trip to Macedonia the morning after they arrived (16:8-11).

After five days of sailing, Paul disembarked in Troas; a small delegation from his company whom he had sent out ahead of him had prepared the community for his arrival (20:4-5). Luke does not mention the purpose of such a delegation, though it likely had a logistical function in Paul's journey. This also recalls Jesus sending His disciples as delegates who would, in a very logistical sense, "get things ready for Him" (Lk. 9:52).

Luke does not reveal any details from the first six days of Paul's time in Troas. However, Luke specifically describes the events that happened on the first day of the week, describing it first of all as the day when Paul broke bread with the church (20:7). Even despite Luke's references to this part of Paul's journey relative to Jewish festivals, it remains unclear whether Luke is using a Semitic or Hellenistic manner of documenting the beginning of a day.¹ In either case, Luke deliberately states that Paul broke bread on Sunday, the first day of the Jewish week. It seems that Luke's intent in including this particular detail was to show that Paul's company worshiped and broke bread specifically on Sunday, the day of Jesus's resurrection (24:1) whereon Jesus too broke bread with His disciples (24:30). If this is truly Luke's intent, then this

¹ The events of Paul's seventh day in Troas may take place either on Saturday night leading into Sunday morning (if observing the Jewish custom that a day begins at sundown) or on Sunday night leading into Monday morning (if observing the Greek custom that a day begins at sunrise) (Conzelmann 169).

text is “the earliest text we have from which it may be inferred with reasonable certainty that Christians regularly came together for worship on that day,” (Bruce 384).

The following passage is a continuation of the overarching “we” narrative that occurs at various points in the second half of Acts. This first person narration, as opposed to the third person narration that most readers of scripture would be familiar with, uniquely transports the audience into the story. The general, anonymous “we” gives the audience members a way to identify themselves among the greater Christian community breaking bread with Paul that Sunday evening (Tannehill 2. 247). This adds both character and immediacy to the passage. Indeed, the use of the first person perspective appeals to the audience’s emotion in a special way, since it lends the passage to a more personal and intimate reading than would be typical of an otherwise standard pericope. The narrator’s involvement in the story imposes limitations on the passage as well, since the narrator is no longer an omniscient chronicler but rather a very human storyteller. This may account for the unbalanced use of detail between both halves of the passage (particularly the latter half’s failure to definitively pronounce Eutychus’s death or resurrection). The first person testimony also implies some degree of historical, eyewitness credibility to the story, although this purpose seems secondary to the emotional enhancement that it brings to the passage (Kurz 113). To a lesser extent, the “we” group that accompanies Paul on his missionary journeys parallels the twelve disciples of Jesus (Kurz 121). Such a parallel strengthens the connection between Jesus and Paul’s journeys and, by extension, also connects Jesus and Paul to each other.

Luke notes that Paul’s meeting with the Troasians on Sunday was, first of all, to break bread with them. The specifics of this practice are left undisclosed in this particular setting. Without context, this practice seems peculiar – surely the Troasians did not wait until after midnight to sup, only for their evening menu to be exclusively bread (Haenchen 586). However, in light of the broader Luke-Acts narrative, Paul’s meal with the Troasians is best understood in keeping with the tradition of the rest of Jesus and the apostles’ table fellowship scenes.

The many meals in Luke-Acts fulfil the definition of *ceremony* in ways that shed fresh light on their content and function. Ceremonies are predictable events which occur regularly... . They are presided over by officials... . They confirm institutions and roles/statuses within those institutions. (Neyrey 374)

The table fellowship scenes of Luke-Acts provide narrative opportunities for characters to further establish their roles in the plot by participating with a certain role in the existing ceremonial institution of a meal. Following this definition, the breaking of bread seems to be an existing ceremonial institution that occurred regularly (that is, every Sunday). By leading the meal, Paul demonstrated his valid apostolic authority by taking the role of an apostle during the breaking of bread meal (cf. 2:42). These ceremonial meals also served to strengthen the identity, values, and structures of the participating group (Neyrey 375). The breaking of bread every Sunday was a uniquely Christian practice; as such, the practices of their ceremony reflect the qualities of the Christian community. During the breaking of bread, Christians were known to devote themselves to the leadership of the apostles in their teachings, prayer, and group fellowship (2:42, 46). In doing so, it also seems that the apostles filled the role of Jesus, who formerly led them too in His teachings, prayer, and fellowship.

Paul’s role at the table is not only to take the place of Jesus, though. As noted earlier, the practice of breaking bread on a Sunday recalls Jesus breaking bread with His disciples on the day

of His resurrection.² Jesus's meal after His resurrection is a critical point in Luke-Acts wherein the scenes of Jesus's table fellowship are replaced by the breaking of bread meals of the disciples. It was a "symbol of restoration of a fellowship broken by death," (Tannehill 1. 290). Thus, the ceremonial meal of the disciples is, to some degree, an act of communing with the risen Christ. Paul's role at the table, it seems, was to stand in as an apostolic representative of Jesus. Paul embraces this role by verbally preaching to the community and by performing a miracle later in the night.

Luke mentions the many lamps that illuminated the room in which they ate (20:8). This environmental detail seems insignificant to Luke's overall narrative. It is possible that Luke intends to set the scene with details whose significance will be revealed later in the narrative. This understanding of the text implies that the lamps (or more properly, the smoke from the lamps) cause Eutychus to retreat to the window for fresh air, and possibly even cause the sleepiness that results in his death (Stott 320). These indeed are practical and likely reasons for Luke's insertion of this detail. However, the detail could have a deeper meaning. Luke's intent could have been to address the pagan accusation that Christians committed heinous acts during their worship that needed to be hidden from the light (Conzelmann 169). Thus, Luke's detail would demonstrate that Christians did not do any actions that needed to be covered up (Packer 169).³ In either case, the fact of the many lamps' presence during their worship remains.

Halfway through the passage, Luke introduces Eutychus (20:9), a young man who drifted off to sleep during Paul's extended sermon. Although it was a common name in the first century world, the name "Eutychus," which literally translates to "fortunate" from the original Greek, is itself a somewhat ironic descriptor for the young Christian.

In Hebrew "Eutychus means senseless, while in Greek it means fortunate." One of these [meanings] fits a person who, through the pleasures of youth, has fallen from the peak of virtues. The other fits a person who, through the loving help of a preacher, has returned to the heights of virtue. (Bede 246)

Thus, it is possible that Luke invented a name for the young man that would be suitable for the narrative, however, such a claim is impossible to validate.

Luke does not directly state the cause for Eutychus's sleepiness, though he does provide multiple possible explanations in the text. Eutychus may have fallen asleep because of the heavy smoke that would have emanated from the many lamps in the upper room. He could have also fallen asleep as a result of disinterest in Paul's discussion. As a young man, he also may have been tired from a day's work, and thus he fell asleep due to the lateness in the night. Indeed, all of these are plausible explanations. It is likely that Luke himself did not even know the exact reason why Eutychus fell asleep. Instead, he provides multiple options for the audience to realize that Eutychus's death was a result of strictly natural causes, unlike Ananias and Sapphira (Acts 5:5, 10). Even though he cannot provide a definite cause for his fall, Luke does not leave room for his audience to question whether or not Eutychus's fall was indeed fatal. Luke specifically notes that Eutychus fell three floors down from the window. This note is specific

² The entire passage in Troas uses language that recalls the events of Jesus's resurrection: the passages both take place on the first day of the week (Lk. 24:1), contain an upper room (Lk. 22:12), and have disciples meeting to break bread (Lk. 24:30) (Johnson 358). Most importantly, not to be overlooked, both passages also have a resurrection.

³ A spiritual reading might also suggest the lamps to be a symbolic response to Jesus's eschatological command to "have your lamps lit," (Lk. 12:35) (Tannehill 2. 250).

enough to indicate to the audience the peril of such a fall. As such, the note justifies the diagnosis in the second half of the verse, which states that Eutychus was “picked up dead.” Additionally, the fact that Luke is a physician (Col. 4:14) should make his diagnosis even more credible – certainly Luke was convinced that Eutychus was dead (Bruce 385).

Before the community even has time to grieve, Paul throws himself upon the dead Eutychus, declaring that “his life is in him,” (20:10). This phrase directly contrasts Luke’s note in the last sentence that he was “picked up dead.” Clearly Paul does not mean that Eutychus miraculously remained alive after the three-story fall (Stott 320). Rather, it seems Eutychus’s life miraculously returned to him only after Paul threw himself upon his lifeless body (Bruce 385). Indeed, Luke intends to convince his audience that both Eutychus’s death and resurrection were in fact literal. Even in the midst of the commotion that must have engulfed the startled community, Paul’s focus faithfully remains on the breaking of bread which apparently has not happened yet. Driven by this motivation, Paul goes back to the upper room to break bread and resumes his discussion with the community (20:11). It is only after Paul leaves that Luke gives any indication about the well-being of the boy after Paul threw himself upon him. Luke merely states that the members of the community “had taken the boy away alive and were not a little comforted,” (20:12). Luke’s description of the events of the night after the boy is raised from the dead seems inappropriate for such a spectacular miracle.

The resurrection of Eutychus is an atypical example of a miracle narrative in Luke-Acts because it does not follow the pre-established patterns of miracle narratives set by Jesus and Peter. There are two previous instances of Jesus or Peter resurrecting the dead: Jesus raising the widow’s son (Lk. 7:11-17) and Peter raising Tabitha (Ac. 9:36-43). Both of these stories more accurately represent the consistent identification of miracle narratives in Luke-Acts. Figure I provided on page 7 displays the common structural elements that are shared between the accounts of Jesus and Peter raising others from the dead. Both begin with a description of the deceased and the miracle worker’s motivation to heal the deceased. Both Jesus and Peter directly address the deceased with a command. Both of these commands function as the critical point of their respective narratives, immediately after which the resurrected individual performs an action that demonstrates their restored vitality. This action that each performs is also assisted by the miracle worker. Finally, both narratives address the community’s response to the miracle and indicate that news of the miracle was spread abroad. The story of Paul raising Eutychus contains none of these elements. The audience knows nothing about Eutychus other than that he was a tired young man. Paul seems to have no direct motivation or emotional connection to the man that motivates him to raise the man from the dead. Paul’s statement that “his life is in him” is very indirect compared to the second person imperative statements delivered by Jesus and Peter. And, unlike the individuals in the other two stories, Luke does not specify any action that Eutychus makes after he is raised. Likewise, the narrative ends without nearly as much fanfare. There is no description whatsoever that news of this miracle was spread abroad nor that the community responded with a great increase of faith. The only response that the Troasian community has is their comfort, a detail that was left out of the previous two accounts.

Instead of following the examples that are seen elsewhere in Luke-Acts, it seems that Luke intended to draw a comparison between Paul’s resurrection of Eutychus with the story of Elisha raising the Shunammite woman’s son (II Kg. 4:32-37). This connection is, like the others, far from perfect. Unlike Elisha, Paul is not seen praying over the dead body (II Kg. 4:33). Indeed, even the paralleled action is not the same in both stories: Paul merely bends over Eutychus and takes him in his arms, whereas Elisha lays his hands, eyes, and even his mouth

upon the deceased (II Kg. 4:34). Additionally, similar to the stories of Jesus and Peter, the resurrected individual sits up and performs an action when he is raised, a detail which is missing from the story of Paul and Eutychus. However, although the text lacks any distinct structural parallels or even many specific elements that connect it to the narrative of Elisha, Paul's bending over the body of the young man is a definite, though modest, connection to the Israelite story (Johnson 356). This connection would have been apparent to an early Christian audience that would have been familiar with the story of Elisha (Haenchen 586). Luke's intention, therefore, was not meant to make an exact connection between Paul and Elisha, but merely to demonstrate Paul's similar authority to miraculously raise individuals from the dead through the power of God.

The passage ends with Paul and his company leaving Troas to continue their journey back to Jerusalem before Pentecost (20:13, 16). As noted earlier, this is an anticlimactic end to such an incredible miracle. However, this adds two important features to the narrative. First, it shows that Paul is determined to reach his destination. Much like Jesus, there is nothing, not even somebody's death and resurrection, that would distract Paul from his mission to reach Jerusalem. Second, the lack of a fitting resolution to the events at Troas gives a certain abruptness to the passage. Whereas the first half of the passage is rife with incidental details that do not seem to be important for the audience to know (such as the day of the week, the time of day, the many lamps, the window, and the three-story elevation), the second half gives the audience whiplash from its lack of clear detail or articulated rhetorical directive.

Luke's dramatic sense seems to have abandoned him completely. He tells us about the many lamps in the room, and the length of Paul's preaching, and the gradually increasing sleepiness (a nice touch), but the dramatic moment of falling and dying and being restored are handled almost casually, and with very little detail. It is possible, of course, that this combination of bare structure and incidental (and relatively disconnected detail) is itself a signal to the reader as to how Luke intends the account to be read. (Johnson 358)

The ambiguity that permeates the would-be climax of the passage heightens the sense of awe and mystery that the audience is meant to experience. Luke does not intend to rationalize the events that took place on that Sunday because doing so might undermine the wonder that the audience is meant to feel after hearing the passage. Yet, almost contradictorily, the casual manner in which the miracle is described shows that, in the age of the Church, miracles and signs are not themselves central aspects of the faith. After the events of Eutychus's resurrection, Paul is still fixated on breaking bread and worshiping with the community in the upper room. It is these rituals, more so than even the greatest miracles, which are foundational to the development of the early Christian Church.

Much like how the anonymous first person "we" invites the audience to identify themselves as onlookers of the events that take place in Troas, the barren structure and incidental details allow the audience to be more fully immersed in the story. The many environmental details that establish the setting of the story encourage the audience to feel present in the upper room. A well-attuned audience can imagine the smoke emanating from the many lamps, the breeze from Eutychus's window, and the crowd's frenzy during the hurried second half of the story. No longer being given information by an omniscient narrator, the audience is forced, alongside the church in Troas, to believe in the events that are being described as an act of faith.

The audience is free to experience the same feelings and emotions as if they were members of the Troasian community.

This self-contained passage offers the audience a wide range of emotions. The audience may find a humorous undertone to the passage: the increasing drowsiness of a boy while Paul drones on well into the night (Dibelius 18). A boy falling asleep during Paul's lengthy discussion is an experience that is so human that an audience might not expect from Sacred Scripture. Of course, Luke also specifically mentions the comfort that the community felt at the end of the night. However, what makes this passage most emotionally significant is its element of tragedy. Eutychus's fall is a tragic interruptor in the middle of the passage. When Eutychus falls, the flow of the story suddenly shifts and panic sets in. "[T]ragedy engulfs the flow of the ordinary. A once vibrant young disciple is dead," (Williamson 154). The sudden burst of tragedy in the middle of Paul's journey should leave an impact on the audience – it adds interest to the otherwise predictable, episodic events of the surrounding narrative.

The lesson to be learned amid all the commotion of the passage, however, is the fact of Paul's authority. Luke portrays Paul as a parallel figure to Elisha and Peter when he resurrects Eutychus. Even more significantly, Luke sees Paul as a later figure of Jesus. Like Jesus, Paul is committed to his journey to Jerusalem, he breaks bread in the upper room with the disciples, and he raises an individual from the dead. Surely the power of Jesus was working in and through Paul during his apostolic ministry (Johnson 358). And, with Jesus working in and through him, Paul's apostolate was also surely equally as valid and authoritative as that of the other apostles.

Ultimately, Paul's second visit to Troas effectively functions to deepen the understanding and experience of Luke's audience. The detailed portion of the text immerses the audience as a worshiping member of the Christian community in Troas, providing insight into Paul's worship practices with the early Christian Church. Luke transforms his audience into witnesses of the events of his narrative so that they may have an emotional response to the tonal shift of the second part of the story. Luke's audience is invited to engage with the emotional and theological elements of the story in a way that prepares them for Paul's journey ahead.

Figure I.

A side-by-side comparison of the only other two resurrection miracle narratives in Luke-Acts using an expanded version of Karl A. Kuhn's general form of a miracle story (Kuhn 84).

	Jesus and the widow's son (Lk. 7:11-17)	Peter and Tabitha (Ac. 9:36-43)
1. Description of the deceased	a man who had died was being carried out. He was his mother's only son, and she was a widow; and with her was a large crowd from the town. (7:12)	Now in Joppa there was a disciple whose name was Tabitha... . She was devoted to good works and acts of charity. At that time she became ill and died. (9:36-37)
2. Description of miracle worker's motivation	He was his mother's only son, and she was a widow... . When the Lord saw her, he had compassion for her (7:12-13)	the disciples, who heard that Peter was there, sent two men to him with the request, "Please come to us without delay." (9:38)
3. Command given to deceased	"Young man, I say to you, rise!" (7:14)	"Tabitha, get up." (9:40)
4. Resurrected performs action	The dead man sat up and began to speak, (7:15)	Then she opened her eyes, and seeing Peter, she sat up. (9:40)
5. Miracle worker helps resurrected perform action	Jesus gave him to his mother. (7:15)	He gave her his hand and helped her up. (9:41)
6. News of miracle spreads	This word about him spread throughout Judea and all the surrounding country. (7:17)	This became known throughout Joppa (9:42)
7. People respond with faith	Fear seized all of them; and they glorified God, saying, "A great prophet has risen among us!" and "God has looked favorably on his people!" (7:16)	and many believed in the Lord. (9:42)

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